

The kingdoms of the Late Bronze Age—Babylonia, Mittani, Elam, Egypt, Mycenae, Alashiya, and the Hittite Empire—were potent powers, whose might was based on the war chariot. Where their frontiers met, they fought, but they made no attempt to conquer each other's core territories, so relative stability was maintained for four centuries from c. 1600 to 1200 BCE.

The flow of bronze

The key to this stability was the need for supplies of copper and tin to make bronze for weapons and tools. Copper was abundant, but the source of tin at the time was in distant Afghanistan. Long-distance trade in metals therefore needed to be maintained, and the states rapidly formed a diplomatic community,



Bronze Age Collapse

In the Late Bronze Age of the Middle East, a diplomatic community of empires maintained a thriving international system based on bronze. Between 1200 and 1050 BCE, the records of these powers hint at tumult and upheaval—then most simply fall eerily silent, signifying a dark age of history.

based on intensive correspondence, dynastic intermarriage, and exchange of gifts. Whatever the current political balance and regardless of who was fighting whom, bronze was delivered.

Diplomacy also allowed the empires to make peace when strategically necessary. For instance, Egypt and Mittani initially fought over southern Syria, but Mittani made peace with Egypt to concentrate on the Hittite threat from the north. The Hittites later came into conflict with the Egyptians, but formed an alliance with them to repel the Assyrians. The Assyrians, formerly vassals of Mittani, were newcomers to the “Club of Great Powers,” and it was some time before these upstarts were fully accepted.

Disintegration of kingdoms

The collapse began c. 1200 BCE. The first sign was that Mycenaean citadels in Greece were destroyed (see p.77), most likely by northern invaders. It seems that dispossessed Mycenaeans flooded outward looking for new lands. This is probably the origin of the story of Troy (see pp.102–03), which equates to a kingdom in Anatolia known to the Hittites as Wilusa.

What follows in the scant records available seems to be a cascade of mass migration, disruption, and destruction. Around 1180 BCE the Hittite Empire abruptly disappeared from history.

Most likely, marauding Mycenaeans drew Hittite forces away from Hattusa, the capital, which was then destroyed by tribes of northern Anatolia, leaving the rest of the empire to fragment.

The Egyptians fought off invasions by groups they called the “Sea Peoples,” whom they blamed for the fall of the

records a few decades later, when its capital, Susa, was sacked. Assyria also fell silent by 1050 BCE for over a century. The last few records speak of endless border skirmishes, as the kings attempted to hold back mass migrations of “Arameans” and “Mushki.”



Hittite capital

The ruins of Hattusa, destroyed around 1180 BCE, were unearthed at Bogazkoy in central Turkey. The palace was burned and the whole city abandoned.

Hittite Empire, although many of these groups seem to have had connections to former Hittite territories, meaning they were probably displaced by the empire's fall, rather than the cause of it. Egypt's New Kingdom declined and eventually fragmented in 1069 BCE.

Meanwhile, Babylonia's wars with Assyria and Elam resulted in Babylon's Kassite dynasty dissolving in 1154 BCE and Elam again disappearing from the

What happened?

This period is one of the most hotly debated subjects in ancient history. The events are known from only a handful of sources, such as the Ugarit letters (see right) and the Egyptian accounts of the Sea Peoples. After 1050, there are simply no records at all and the period 1050–934 BCE is termed a “dark age.” The collapse represented only the removal of the top layer of culture, however—a dark age is simply a period in which the elite stop producing monuments and written records. The political map was redrawn, but the lives of most people would not have changed.

Although many kingdoms fell, only a few cities were utterly destroyed. Assyria and Elam were the only Bronze Age powers to return, but new kingdoms soon arose. The patterns of the Bronze Age were still deeply ingrained, but the new technology of iron would soon allow states such as Assyria (see pp.80–81) to break free of the old system of diplomacy and bid for world domination on their own.

New kingdoms, including the Hebrew states of Israel and Judah, were founded in the former territory of the Bronze Age powers.

ARAMAEAN KINGDOMS

Migrations were a key feature of the collapse, and the most significant migrants were the Aramaeans. By the 10th century BCE, a patchwork of small Aramaean kingdoms covered the Levant and northern Mesopotamia, and the Aramaic language was on its way to replacing Akkadian << 54–55 as the Middle East's *lingua franca*. Aramaic was used in the Assyrian 80–81 >> and Persian 92–93 >> empires.

PHILISTINES

These people settled on the coast of the Levant at the end of the 2nd millennium BCE. They may equate to the *Peleset*—one of the “Sea Peoples” mentioned by the Egyptians—and are the origin of the name *Palestine*. Their architecture and culture appear Greek, suggesting that they began as displaced Mycenaeans << 77.



PHILISTINE FUNERARY MASK

IRON-AGE ECONOMY

Iron ore was more readily accessible than the ingredients for bronze, but the transition to an iron economy was highly disruptive, so the great powers stuck with bronze. After they fell, iron came into common use. By the 10th century BCE, Assyria was making the change, and the emerging new states were already using iron.

HOW WE KNOW

THE UGARIT LETTERS

Correspondence survives between the king of Ugarit, a regional ruler of the Hittite Empire, and the king of Alashiya, on Cyprus. The letters talk of hostile marauders plaguing the Ugarit area and are brought to a sudden stop soon after 1200 BCE by the city's destruction. They mention that the Hittites had called the bulk of Ugarit's forces away to fight elsewhere, leaving it defenseless. The marauders are never named but, as many cities around Ugarit were left unscathed, it is possible that they were displaced Mycenaean Greeks looking for a rich port to loot, as with the suspected fate of Troy.



LETTER AND ENVELOPE